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Hiring Committee
Mahon Library, Lubbock Municipal Libraries
City of Lubbock
1314 Avenue K, Lubbock, TX 79401

Dear Hiring Committee,

I am applying for the Part-Time Library Aide position at the Mahon Library. The work your posting describes, emptying returns, sorting and routing items, reshelving accurately and keeping the shelves in order, is what I already spend my working days doing, over a collection of printed fundraising mail rather than library books.

My title is Direct Mail Production Manager at Young Americans for Liberty, and the collection I look after is the organization's archive of everything it has printed and mailed. A fundraising letter that went to the whole donor file, a proposal prepared for one major donor, the invitation set for a conference: a sample of every piece comes back from the printer and I am the one who takes it in. I sort and label what arrives, shelve it by campaign and mail code, keep the shelves accurate as the collection grows across campaign years, and pull a past piece when a writer or a director needs something to work from. It is a working collection that people retrieve from constantly rather than boxes in a closet.

When I inherited it, finding anything in it meant already knowing where it was. I designed a SQL database for the collection, defined a consistent record for every piece covering mail code, campaign, date, format, audience and vendor, and worked back through several campaign years cataloging the existing material against that standard. On top of the database I built a searchable reading room, so anyone in the department can find a piece and see where the physical original sits on the shelf. That project is where I learned why consistent records matter, and it is why a job like this one reads to me as skilled work rather than simple work.

Your posting asks for someone who can carry out detailed routines at a high rate of accuracy. As a student registrar at Chapman University's Fowler School of Law I processed and approved more than five hundred transcripts, exam records and bar documents, where a misfiled record had consequences for somebody's graduation. I staffed the service window there as well, as the first person students talked to, so helping somebody at a desk is familiar ground.

Before my current role I was Development Manager at the University of Austin, where part of my work was the campus library. The university was building that library largely from donated books, and I took the donations in and documented them. One gift I handled from the first conversation through to the books being shelved was a complete *Harvard Classics* set: I worked with that donor throughout, gave them a tour of the library in person, and kept them updated on where the set had been placed. I also led visitor tours generally. That is the work that turned a general interest in libraries into wanting to do this for a living.

Outside work I built two public websites: the Free Knowledge Library, a digital library of political literature drawn from across the ideological spectrum, where I designed the site, the database and the classification scheme and built the catalog readers search; and statetrack.net, which I developed to publish state campaign finance records for state house and state senate candidates in all fifty states.

I should be straightforward about why I am applying for a part-time aide position. I begin a Library and Information Services certificate at Central Community College in the spring and have already started the ALA's Library Support Staff Certification, with a master's in library and information science to follow. Working in a library while I study is worth a good deal more to me than the hours suggest, because it is the practical experience the coursework assumes you are getting somewhere, and I would rather build it behind a desk than only on paper. I should say plainly that I am able to relocate. I am in Austin now, and I am willing to move anywhere in Texas a position requires.

Thank you for your consideration. I would welcome the chance to talk about the role.

Sincerely,

Neal T. Gillespie